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Explicit

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by ari_kari

Summary

Catra flees through the Whispering Woods. Adora chases after her. And instead of grabbing her by the wrists in their final encounter, Adora pushes Catra a bit further.

Things diverge quickly from there.

Notes

welcome to my prospective series unofficially titled “what if they just fucking kissed” where I change one (1) tiny detail of the plot and it spirals quickly into lesbian sex. as it turns out there are many places in the plot where this is not only possible but highly likely. enjoy 🍾

See the end of the work for more notes

"Catra!"

No. This isn't happening.

She takes off running without looking back, Melog padding at her heels. Childish? Perhaps. But there's no way Catra is going to sit back and listen to yet another hero's speech from the *savior of Etheria*. She's had enough, at this point, to last her a lifetime.

Maybe Catra underestimates her, though. Adora doesn't bother calling after her again - she just breaks into a sprint, her breathing growing louder as she closes the gap from behind. Catra swears internally at Adora's athleticism, even as she channels all her energy into propelling herself forward. Of course she's still faster, after all these years. Of course she won't just *give it up*.

In a last-ditch effort to evade her, Catra lunges for a nearby branch just above height's-reach. She manages to snag it, pull herself up to her shoulders - but no. Adora drags her down, landing on top of her and crushing Catra beneath her weight. Even after Catra elbows her off, crawling on her stomach to get away, Adora refuses to relent. She *drags Catra by the leg*, then uses her knapsack to get the upper hand.

Before Catra knows it, Adora is surging forward - hard - and knocking the air from Catra's lungs as she slams her to the ground.

"You were just gonna *leave?"*

Catra hisses with the impact. Adora has her pinned to the floor now, wrists gripped tightly in each hand. She thrashes against Adora's grip - only to feel Adora's thighs tighten around her, solidifying her hold even more.

"Let *go* of me!" Catra spits. But Adora doesn't budge.

"*No*." Her expression is one of frantic determination - the failsafe sharpens her features in the shadow of its deadly glow. "I'm not letting you leave. Not until you *talk to me.*"

"We have *nothing* to talk about." Catra is overwhelmed by Adora's closeness; she can see the individual furrows of her brow, the bite marks on her upper lip. Their hearts pound from exertion. "I'm doing you a favor. Now you can go save the world, without having to worry about me *confusing you*."

There is a split second after Catra speaks…no. She is imagining it. Adora's eyes do not fall to her lips. Adora does not want her.

It is over before Catra has time to process.

"That's not true." Adora's grip on Catra's wrists loosens slightly; her mind is clearly working overtime. "Don't - don't listen to Shadow Weaver. This isn't about her."

Fury burns through Catra's body. Those soft blue eyes are locked onto her face now, raw with hurt and confusion. Idiot. She has no idea what's really going on. She *never* has.

Without warning, Catra summons every ounce of her strength and yanks herself out of Adora's grip. She then barrels into Adora's body at full force, slamming her backwards onto the earth. And Catra can escape, now - she knows she can - but she doesn't. She just pins Adora by the wrists the same way she'd been pinned before, bodies now dangerously close as the air puffs forcefully from Adora's lungs.

"Then what *is* it about?" Catra cries.

Adora is out of breath. Her eyes are dark, and frightened - and flick down to Catra's lips, just for a moment. But it's nothing. It is *nothing*.

"Seriously, Adora. I need to know." Her voice cracks on the last sentence; she tightens her grip in response. "Why do you always

need to sacrifice everything for everyone else? When do *you* get to choose?"

The question seems to rob Adora of her remaining strength; Catra can feel her going soft beneath her grip. She is mere centimeters apart, close enough for Catra to feel the puff of her breath. Her body is warm; intoxicating. Catra wants to scream until her lungs give out.

"What do you want?" she asks instead, fighting vigorously to keep tears from spilling onto her cheeks. "What do you *want*, Adora?"

A quick pause, Then, Adora's eyes move down to Catra's lips - unmistakably, this time.

No.

"I…" Adora stammers. Her eyes flicker up. Down again. Stay there.

This is not happening. It is not fucking happening, here and now. Even as Adora's breath releases slowly against Catra's cheek, her lips parting in what can only be an unspoken invitation, Catra simply refuses to accept it. The pounding of Adora's heart against her chest is just adrenaline. She couldn't…it's not...

Fuck.

Catra's grip has loosened now; more of a suggestion than a true hold. Adora doesn't move. In the back of her mind, it occurs to Catra that Melog has vanished. Adora's lips are soft and full.

Catra's eyes squeeze shut. To block her out; block *reality* out, any way she can. But she can still feel Adora's body pinned beneath her, and the energy vibrating unmistakeably between them - and it is not *fucking fair.* She cannot get everything she's ever wanted, hours before the universe rips it away from her. Not after everything. She would rather have the nothing. She can't -

Adora pulls her down and kisses her.

The world goes quiet.

There are no thoughts. No interpretations. Only Adora's mouth - chapped from dehydration, but softer, still, than Catra had ever imagined. A tiny voice from far away tells her that she is asleep; dreaming. She concurs. Adora is not kissing her. That doesn't happen in real life.

Catra parts her lips to accept her. Of course she would; it's what she always does, in dreams. But Adora gasps when she feels it - this quiet little squeak of delight at the contact - and the full force of reality slams into Catra like a battering ram. Adora is kissing her. *Adora* is kissing *her*.

She surges forward - just as Adora's fists tighten in her shirt - and something shatters between them.

The kiss is an act of violence, decades of energy and fury colliding at breakneck speed. They shake off their inexperience quickly - or maybe Catra just ceases to give a shit - as lips cede to tongues, and both whine in desperation for another taste of each other. Rational thought in Catra's mind is obliterated. She kisses Adora like she's starving; she takes without restraint, and finds Adora surprisingly willing to make urgent demands of her own.

They fall sideways quickly, their needs to escape and pursue forgotten. Now both seem determined to merge their bodies into one, grabbing at each other with such unchecked furiosity Catra fears they might bruise. Her claws scrabble for the back of Adora's neck, just sharp enough to mark, and Adora *responds* - threading her hands in Catra's hair and grasping so hard that Catra cries out against her mouth. It's the most sensation she's ever felt at once, burning through every synapse like pure electricity, and it's still not enough. Nothing could *possibly* be enough.

Then Adora shoves her thigh directly between Catra's legs, intentionally or otherwise - and *fuck*, that's it. It's borderline involuntary, the way she jerks roughly against her leg in response; Adora gasps like she can feel the spark too. And all the while, her

tongue is still in Catra's mouth, pushing eagerly past her lips again and again - and she is not going to make it. She cannot possibly survive this, and at this point, she doesn't give a single, solitary *fuck*.

Her hips roll subtly against Adora's, at first; enough for it to be passed off as an expression of enthusiasm. But every moment of contact carries an unspoken request - *please let me do this. Let me fuck myself on your body in the middle of the woods, minutes after doing my best to escape. Let me do this thing with you we've never even talked about. Let me, let me, let me.*

And she's going to. Catra knows it. Because after one particularly-obvious thrust forward, Adora's right hand shifts from tugging her hair to gripping her ass - such an uncharacteristic display of crudeness that Catra can't help but whimper as desire floods her body. And she realizes that they are on the exact same page - they *cannot* think. This is the most phenomenal fucking thing that has ever happened, and if either of them stop to consider their actions, for even *one* second, it will all fall apart.

Fuck it. She threads her own hands through Adora's hair - gripping hard enough to steady herself, to make Adora moan - and bears down on her leg with intent. Immediately, there is an arm wrapping around her upper back, pulling her so crushingly close she can barely breathe, while the other stays firmly planted on her ass. And as Catra's movements progress from occasional rolls to a slow, hard grind, it's *Adora* moans with every jerking movement, her breath growing increasingly choked as Catra rides her with impunity.

She is ridiculous. Absolutely ridiculous. For holding Catra like this, and getting off on her pleasure, and being so fucking *perfect* Catra can barely stand it. Her scent is all around them, filling Catra up from the inside; Catra is sweating, and trembling, and breaking apart from friction alone. And even now, with lust overheating her body, she's furious. Furious that Adora has wanted her all this time, and only bothered to show it when it was too late. Furious at herself, for all the pain she's caused. Furious

about how badly she needs this. How much she needs Adora; loves her.

Fuck. Catra *loves* her. She loves her more than anything.

Her arms have worked their way around Adora's back now, crushing her close; Adora's wrap tightly around her waist. Catra's too far gone to kiss her, so she settles for mouthing at the base of her neck, canines rubbing against the taut skin beneath. They are both fighting to keep quiet, and doing horribly, and it is all Catra can do to keep her claws sheathed as her hips begin to move involuntarily and the tension reaches a breaking point inside her.

And somehow, in those last moments of control, she locks onto something subtle - a faint murmuring near her ear. It's quiet enough that Catra knows Adora doesn't want her to hear, and that's what breaks her, in the end. Because the word is the same every time - mouthed over and over like a feverish incantation, airless and desperate.

"Catra. Catra. *Catra*."

She hurdles over the edge.

Catra's cry is loud enough that it would probably worry her, if worrying were something she was remotely capable of right then. She isn't. There is nothing on the planet but Adora's thigh between her legs, and her skin in Catra's mouth, and the bliss pulsing violently through every part of her. Adora is holding her as tightly as Catra needs her to, hand threaded through the back of Catra's hair as she rides through the aftershocks. For a moment, Catra chases the highs of pleasure and closeness without thought. She forgets the war. Forgets herself.

But she can't avoid the comedown forever. It creeps into her bliss like a toxin, sickening and inevitable, as tension drains slowly from her body. Even through the haze of endorphins, Catra begins to remember that the body holding her in its grip is a person - one that she loves more than anything. And it dawns on her, as Catra

lies exhausted in her arms, that she had used Adora for pleasure without even *attempting* to reciprocate. Catra the taker, Adora the giver. Same as it ever was.

Now, Adora is pressing soft, easy kisses against Catra's temple and cheeks; she's loosened her grip only enough for both of them to breathe. And that's what really sets her off - because it would be one thing if this had been some sort of random impulse fuck, a final, adrenaline-fueled mistake at the end of universe. But Adora is kissing Catra's face like it was the best thing that's ever happened to her. And it dissolves what's left of Catra's defenses. Sends her whole world crashing down around her before she can even process it.

Too late, Catra realizes she's crying.

It's only a few moments later that Adora picks up on the heaving in Catra's chest, finally pulling back enough to inspect her face. Catra can already see the alarm in Adora's eyes, mixed with that overwhelming tenderness she's never deserved. Adora lifts her hand to stroke the tears from her cheek - and Catra immediately flinches backwards, humiliated and heartbroken and still furious, in spite of it all.

"I'm sorry," she hears Adora whisper. "I didn't mean to push you. I -"

Catra surges forwards and pulls Adora into a backbreaking hug.

"Shut *up*," Catra replies forcefully. Her voice cracks at the end. "Stop apologizing. Just - *stop*."

If Adora understands, she doesn't indicate it. But she doesn't repeat the apology. After a moment of hesitation, she moves her arms around Catra's lower back, tentatively pulling her closer…and an undignified sob bursts from Catra's chest. It's all she can do at that point to bury her face in Adora's neck and hide as the pain overwhelms her entire body, and she finally falls apart in Adora's arms.

They stay like that for a while; Catra cries hard and quiet, body wracked with sobs as she clutches tiny pinpricks in Adora's shirt. Adora continues to hold her throughout, stroking her with that same unbridled tenderness. It makes Catra sick with shame.

Eventually, there is nothing left. The weight of Catra's fatigue pulls her down, her sobs easing to whimpers and eventually to silence. Tiny details - the dampness of the grass beneath them, the chirruping of insects in the night - slowly filter into her awareness. She can see the failsafe glowing menacingly through her eyelids.

She will never be able to bridge the gap between them. It has been yawning ever-wider from the moment Adora picked up that sword, and no amount of heroic sacrifices will ever truly close it. They will die like this, both of them; Adora the personification of goodness and light, Catra the rot that devours her from within. It's all they've ever been meant for. Maybe if Catra starts now, she might have time to make peace with that.

"The universe has you in it."

Catra stills.

Adora's tone is calm - notably so. But she can't keep the tremble out of her voice entirely. Catra feels her take a long, deep breath, clearly trying to steady herself.

Her voice is stronger when she speaks again.

"That's why I have to save it." Another breath; her fingers have gone still in Catra's fur. "You live here. You're a part of it."

Catra's heart aches.

She lingers only a moment in Adora's warmth, reluctant to disrupt the quiet security of their embrace. But Adora has stilled around her; she knows it's time. So after a deep breath of her own, Catra pulls back from her grip and settles a few inches in front of Adora's face. She opens her eyes and looks at her - really looks at her - for the first time since this started.

Adora is scared.

There are other emotions present as well. Hurt. Grief. That underlying fatigue they've both been carrying for weeks now, and probably longer than that. But mostly, she's just scared. Her eyes are bloodshot - maybe from tears of her own - and there's a sense of fragility in her expression that's frightening. Like she could come apart at any second.

The self-critical voice in Catra's head goes silent.

She reaches for the ponytail first - what remains of it, at least, after what they just did. She manages to snag it on her claw without breaking it, pulling it from Adora's hair as gently as she can. Adora's eyes flutter slightly at the touch. If she's surprised by the gesture, she doesn't say anything about it.

With the ponytail out of the way, Catra begins combing gently through her hair. Adora's eyes fall shut as her palm makes contact with her scalp; Catra has to resist the sudden, overpowering urge to kiss her right on her eyelids. All that can wait. Adora needs something else right now.

"It didn't have to be you," Catra finally replies, brushing carefully through her strands. Her voice is thick. "It doesn't always have to be you."

Adora's brow furrows slightly. Her eyes remained closed. "I'm the only one who has a chance."

Catra can feel her eyes well up with tears again; she blinks them back, focusing all her energy on providing consistent, gentle touch. "It still didn't have to be you."

Adora just sighs. She looks a lot more exhausted than she had before. It's been a while since Catra was permitted access to this level of vulnerability.

"I know," she murmurs.

Catra sighs.

She can feel the grief she's been struggling to repress all afternoon rising to the surface again as the heat of Adora's scalp radiates into her palm. She doesn't look like the savior of anyone's universe right now - just a tired, scared kid, grappling with a burden she can hardly fathom. Shadow Weaver had nearly forced the responsibility onto her without even giving her a choice. And it was typical, wasn't it? Adora has never gotten a choice.

With a jolt, the full magnitude of what Catra had almost done crashes down on her. She was going to leave Adora to face that burden alone. Leave her to *die* alone, in the center of the planet - and for what? Some imagined sense of betrayal? The assumption that Catra's presence wouldn't matter enough to make a difference?

No. She'd been wrong. She realizes that now.

Adora leans into her touch more and more with every passing moment. In spite of everything that has happened - the fighting, the yelling, the boundaries Catra had crossed - Adora still seems to want her. It's beyond humbling. And it makes her wonder; what else does Adora want, beneath her masks of duty and obedience? Does she yearn for Catra even half as much as Catra desires her?

Catra decides to start slow.

Her hand trails first from Adora's hair to her jawline. When she runs her thumb over Adora's bottom lip, she can immediately sense her breath quicken. Catra can feel the thickness of it beneath her fingertip, full and soft as she'd always dreamed it would be; it makes her heart skip. After a moment of hesitation, Adora surrenders to her touch and, ever-so-slightly, allows her lips to part.

Heat flushes through Catra's body.

"I didn't know you wanted this with me," she murmurs, more to herself than anything. Her heart beats in her throat as she traces

Adora’s lip, barely edging against the wetness inside. “I thought I was the only one.”

Adora’s eyelids slide open as she meets Catra’s gaze - and for a split second, Catra’s body is gripped with terror. Maybe she’d interpreted everything wrong. Maybe Adora had just felt scared, watching her get off like that; pressured.

But something darkens in those pretty blue eyes as they stare into Catra’s own. And a warm line of heat passes down through Catra’s center.

“I think I’ve always wanted you,” she whispers - and oh, Catra is *gone*. Adora’s eyes flicker down to the thumb on her lips, latching onto it with obvious hunger. “I just didn’t know what it meant, or - or how to say it. I didn’t want to ruin everything.”

It is more than Catra can process, finally hearing those words. She’s fantasized about them for longer than she can remember. “You couldn’t. You never could.”

Adora’s eyes flutter shut at that. After a moment, she purses her lips to kiss Catra’s thumb; withdraws. When she opens her eyes, her expression is somber.

“You know that's not true,” she replies simply.

Catra feels her blood freeze.

She’s right. It sickens her to admit, but they both know she’s right - Catra’s affections have been far from unconditional these past few years. She’d abandoned Adora for leaving a tyrannical regime; abandoned her for choosing to actually do some good in the world, and help the people they’d hurt. And if Adora hadn’t stopped her…Catra would’ve abandoned her again. She’d have left Adora to die in the center of the planet - utterly alone, screaming in pain - all for the slightest chance that it would spare her an ounce of grief.

Shame overwhelms her body so completely she can barely stand it. She has to squeeze her eyes shut to keep tears from spilling onto her cheeks. Catra will never be worthy of this, not as long as she lives. She is poison - just like everyone's always said she is - and she always, always will be.

She feels Adora's hand on her cheek, sweet and patient as ever. And this is the part, Catra knows, where she's supposed to run. Remove herself from the equation, ticking time bomb that she is; prevent further damage. She hadn't fully ruled it out, if she's being completely honest. The urge to spare Adora her presence is overwhelming.

But there's another urge within her, too - a quiet certainty she's never known. And to Catra's own surprise, it washes away the old hurt and ebbs into the rest of her, filling her with an unfamiliar sense of serenity. Adora's hand on her jaw grounds her to the present; encourages her to open her eyes. And when their gazes lock, only one thought passes through her mind.

I am going to give you exactly the kind of love that you deserve.

Without allowing herself time to think, Catra rolls over until she's on top again, pinning Adora's hips gently with her own. Adora exhales sharply at the sudden change of position, her hands threading tightly into the grass beneath her. And Catra can't tell exactly what Adora sees in her eyes when they lock - but whatever it is makes her skin flush pink.

Catra brings her hand to the plane of Adora's abdomen; the other girl's breath stalls completely. Slowly and surely, she begins to move it up Adora's torso - past her solar plexus, just below her breasts, then over and through the failsafe. By the time her hand finally settles over Adora's heart, her pulse is frantic, and Catra has gotten close enough to feel Adora's breath against her face. Her eyes lock onto Catra like she's the most powerful force in the universe.

“Adora,” she says quietly. She kisses both cheeks, gentle and slow - then brings their foreheads together. Exhales. “I’m not going anywhere.”

Catra can already feel Adora’s body beginning to tremble when she presses their lips together once again.

It’s miles away from the ruthlessness of their first experience. The desperation is still there, running like an undercurrent through every point of contact - but there’s a sweetness, too. Already, Catra is beginning to know and love the feeling of Adora’s mouth against her own. She can’t help but feel like their bodies were designed to fit together that way.

Still, she wastes little time trailing from Adora’s lips to her neck - a place she’d fantasized about kissing for months now, curled up in bed with her onboard Darla. Maybe Adora feels the same. The touch of Catra’s mouth pulls a whimper from her throat; she wraps her arms around Catra’s back, pulling her closer, like she can’t bear even an inch of separation between them.

“Catra.” Her voice is barely above a whisper as Catra’s lips find the hollow of her throat. “*Catra*.”

The sound of her name sparks a desperate heat between Catra’s legs. She channels it into ever-more aggressive kisses that eventually make their way lower, onto the jut of Adora’s collarbone and the soft skin between. She can feel frustration building inside her - there are clothes in the way, heavy and useless, and she wants them *off* Adora’s body with a ferocity that startles her.

She slips her fingers beneath the hem of Adora’s shirt, partly to test Adora’s willingness and partly just to make contact. The exhale that follows tells Catra that she’d made the right call - and she barely gets a chance to explore beneath her top before Adora is reaching down to pull it over her own head, working it over her shoulders in an instant and falling back, breathless, once she’s freed. She’s still wearing her sports bra; she never takes that

thing off, even in bed. But the sight of Adora's body alone, dirt-smeared and muscular and carved from rock, is enough to whet her appetite for now. All these years spent sneaking glances in locker rooms and training simulations, and now? She can admire freely. She can *touch*.

Catra makes full use of her hands and mouth to lavish attention on every part of her - and Adora lets her, quickly going pliant beneath Catra's adoring palms. Every once in a while she'll come across a spot that makes Adora melt a little more - draws sweet noises of pleasure from her mouth - and Catra can't help but sigh right along with her. How many nights had she succumbed to the fantasy of exploring Adora with her lips? How vividly and frequently had she imagined this, despite the intolerable swells of longing it triggered within her? But Catra was here now. She was kissing Adora everywhere, and Adora was loving it, and it was so, so much better than Catra had ever dreamt of.

Not everything fits the fantasy, though. Even in Catra's most masochistic daydreams, she'd never conjured anything like the failsafe - a beacon of destruction, shining through Catra's eyelids no matter how tightly she squeezed them. It is an unpleasant reminder that they are no longer teenagers in a bunk room, whispering secrets and giggling over nothing. They are adults in the penultimate days of an intergalactic war. One whose outcome, even now, is widely out of both of their control.

There are things Catra can do, though - an entire world of exploration long barred to her, and spread before her now in an overwhelming array. So she focuses on that. Her kisses get harder; she begins sucking Adora's skin into her mouth, lightly at first, then hard enough to bruise. And that seems to erode the last of Adora's restraint. She starts whimpering with every pull, emotional boundaries finally dissolved by Catra's slow and steady work. That's right around the time that Catra finds a sweet spot - the ball of her hip, just below the waistband of her pants.

Adora cries out; her hips buck against Catra's mouth, immediately shifting the energy into something urgent. Within seconds Catra

feels a set of hands in her hair, pulling her up the length of Adora's body with nearly enough force to hurt. But it doesn't - or it does, and she likes it - and she barely has time to breathe before Adora's is shoving her tongue in her mouth, her grip so tight in Catra's hair she can't help but cry out.

"*Adora*." She says it between kisses; out of shock, and arousal, and the simple need to hear it. Adora responds by whimpering into Catra's mouth with a helplessness she's never heard before, and it sparks such a powerful current between Catra's legs that she loses herself to the intensity.

Things spiral quickly; their bodies merge until they are nothing more than mouths and sweat, tangled limbs and heat. Only the vaguely-remembered threat danger keeps them quiet, and even then, they aren't nearly as careful as they should be. When Adora finally moves to free herself from her sports top, Catra assists with such reckless enthusiasm that she scratches Adora's side with her claws. And she almost apologizes, despite the delirium of the moment - but the pain makes Adora *moan*, her breasts bouncing gorgeously as they're freed, and Catra barely has time to appreciate the sight before she's dropping down and sucking Adora's nipple directly into her mouth.

Adora makes a sound like she's been struck - a pained half-sob, accompanied by a sudden, violent jerk of Adora's hips. Her legs squeeze Catra from both sides, enough to take her breath away. And right as Catra realizes she's pushed Adora to her limit - that she can be edged no further - Adora speaks

"Please." She has never spoken like this; never begged. "Catra. *Please*."

Raw desire crashes through her body.

No more teasing. She yanks Adora's pants to her ankles, revealing a pair of visibly-soaked grey boxers that make her heart seize. Adora cannot possibly be this wet for *her;* clearly, she has been dreaming from the start. This is just another torment of her

broken mind, and she will wake up on her sleep pad with the empty remains of it buzzing between her legs.

But no. Catra is wide awake - and Adora is already nudging the waistband of her underwear over her hips, ready to be done with them. Catra snaps out of her reverie just in time to help her, Adora settles on her back after she's freed… and there it is. A sight so beautiful Catra can hardly process it; soaked, golden curls adorning perfect lips, ready and open and hers.

She is completely overwhelmed.

Catra has only done this once, and only on the receiving end - because of course she hadn't reciprocated for Scorpia, drunk on cactus wine and even more of an asshole because of it. The mechanics had been the same, then, but the act itself couldn't have been further removed. It was a moment borne of impulse and cruelty - worlds apart from putting your mouth on the girl you loved.

She hesitates too long; Adora tenses. Catra can feel her reverie drop like the flip of a switch as her guards shoot up around her.

"You don't have to." Adora sounds hesitant now - *fuck*. "I know it's - it's a lot. You can stop."

Catra's body floods with remorse. When is she going to stop screwing things up? Adora thinks she doesn't want this, now - nothing could be further than the truth. Adora has to know that.

Catra needs to tell her.

"Adora." She waits for Adora to lock eyes with her as she fights to get her own breathing under control. "I want this - so bad. *Please* let me."

Adora's breath catches in her throat. The tension in her body dissolves in a light tremble as she stares deep into Catra's eyes. She's the most beautiful thing that Catra has ever known. Catra would rather die than allow her to assume otherwise.

“I want it, too.” Her voice is small and vulnerable. “If you do.”

Catra has never been more determined to show her *exactly* how much she does.

She begins to kiss Adora again; first on the soft skin of her inner thigh, and then on her underwear line, gentle, barely-there presses of her lips that send shivers through Adora’s body. When she finally allows her tongue to drift against her outer lips, she’s rewarded with a gasp from Adora and the barest tastes of slick on her skin. Then Adora’s hands are threading through her hair - no longer able to restrain herself from asking without words - and Catra finally, *finally* throws caution to the wind and licks deep into Adora’s center.

Their moans are synchronous; Adora’s at the sensation, Catra’s at the sheer, blissful overwhelm of Adora’s taste. She continues to savor it, dipping into her entrance before circling languidly around it - and she realizes that she has never felt right in herself, truly, until this exact moment. Fuck the badge, and the Horde, and her caustic dreams of world domination. She was born to live between this girl’s legs and do whatever it took to make her feel good. How she’d made it so long without realizing it was beyond her.

When Catra’s lips finally settle around Adora’s bud, she feels hands tighten in her hair, and she recognizes the unspoken signal for more. She delivers, suckling it gently into her mouth - and based on the instinctive way Adora tugs her close, she thinks that was the right call. Soon Adora’a making little crying noises with every stroke of Catra’s tongue, rolling into the sensation, and Catra grips both thighs *hard* - and the boundaries between Adora’s body and hers vanish, all at once, as if they’d never existed. From that point on, they lose themselves. Nothing exists but Adora’s hot, trembling body, and her barely-stifled cries in the dark, and her helpless little thrusts against Catra’s mouth that grow increasingly jerky with time. She knows she’s sloppier than she should be, at this point; her jaw is giving out. But she doesn’t care. She *does not* fucking care.

“You’re good.” Fuck, Adora is - she’s *slurring*. “You’re so good, Catra. So, so good.”

She’s close. Catra can feel the climax escalating in her body, driving her senselessness; the thrusts are coming fast enough now that Catra knows she’s losing control. In the heat of the moment, she lets her claws come out against Adora’s legs, just hard enough to break skin - and she immediately feels powerful thighs crushing her head as a choked, wordless cry escapes Adora’s lips. There are only a few frantic jerks upward after that before Adora goes mute with pleasure and her climax shudders through her entire body.

The air seems to vibrate around them as Adora grinds, hard and slow, through the peak. Her muscles tense and release against Catra’s head with every wave of bliss - and Catra is going to die. She is dying, already, feeling this beautiful girl fall apart against her, and as Adora’s body flexes slightly one last time before easing into total surrender, she is more convinced than ever that she has entered a realm better and more impossible anything she has ever known.

Adora finally exhales, her left leg falling sideways against the damp forest floor - and Catra realizes she hasn’t drawn breath in a while. Air fills her lungs in short gasps. Even still, she cannot help but rest her open mouth on the soft inner skin of Adora’s thigh, lips half-pursed, just to have a point of contact. For a moment both are silent as they struggle to find themselves.

Adora doesn’t let her rest for very long. It seems like mere seconds have passed before the hand in Catra’s hair is tugging upward with quiet urgency, inviting her up the length of Adora’s body’s. Along the way, Catra leaves quick kisses on every divot of muscle she can find - relishes in the feeling of Adora’s hard, strong body, cultivated for war, finally relaxed beneath her touch. She doesn’t pay undue attention to the failsafe, but she doesn’t skip over it, either. It is a part of this body. She loves this body.

When Catra finally makes it face-to-face, there is a strange sort of desperation in Adora's eyes that concerns her. Then she starts running her hands over Catra's body, her fingers trembling - and all too quickly, Catra understands

"I wanna do that." She's still groggy from the comedown; still completely out of breath. "I want to - I wanna do that for you. Please."

The vulnerability in Adora's voice hurts to hear, even as Adora's wandering hands send a renewed flush of heat through Catra's body. Adora is so desperate to reciprocate. She cannot stand to be the center of attention for even one moment.

It fills her heart with sorrow.

"Adora," she whispers, covering Adora's restless hands with her own to still them. She makes a conscious effort to slow her own breath. "Take it easy. You're OK."

Adora's still panting. Catra can feel the heat against her fur. But eventually, she manages a long, shaky breath. Her hands slip from Catra's own and find her lower back, carding through the fur; Catra can feel her own heart rate begin to slow in tandem.

"There you go," she mumurs soothingly. She lifts her hands to cup Adora's jaw and looks into her eyes; still a little frantic, but doing their best to focus on Catra's face. Catra strokes Adora's cheek with her thumb, and sees her expression soften a bit.

"Good." Her eyes flicker to Adora's lips. "Just relax."

She leans in.

It's gentle, now; more than before. There is still feel untapped energy humming between them - but Adora follows her lead, keeping their kisses slow and languid to start. Catra spends a few seconds just stroking her jawline, up and down; waits for Adora to relax into the contact. Only she senses that Adora is calm and focused does Catra finally relent.

Without rushing, she guides one of Adora's hands from her back to her abdomen. It's her way of giving permission - saying "now is ok." Adora touches her with just as much eagerness as before, but there's far less panic in her motions; she's taking time to savor the experience. To linger in the feeling of Catra's body, instead of rushing to reciprocate. With that, Catra finally surrenders - lets Adora take the reins, willingly, for the first time in her life.

Adora continues their easy pace at first, confining her touches to the plane of Catra's stomach. Heat sparks between Catra's legs each time her fingers dip near the waistband; it grows warmer and steadier with each cautious touch, building in strength until it eventually takes on a life of its own.

Perhaps Adora can tell. She begins to tease Catra a bit with her mouth - pinning her bottom lip gently with her teeth, humming at Catra's soft gasps of pleasure. The energy between them begins to thrum as Adora's chest brushes, gently and rhymically, against Catra's own, sending her mind into a spiral. She's imagined this enough times for it to feel like a memory - but a lifetime of stolen touches was poor preparation for the bliss of sustained contact. For the sheer, overwhelming *feel* of her.

Soon, the intensity has built enough for Adora to wind up on top again. Catra's mind flits back a few minutes before, when she'd been pinned down by Adora in a very different context. The circumstances have reversed, but the energy in Adora's eyes is much the same. Like she's desperate to convey something she can't quite vocalize in words.

Catra feels Adora searching for direction as they edge closer to the point of no return. But she's finding it difficult to stop pulling Adora down to cradle her face and kiss her, again and again and again. A part of her is still in awe that it's allowed. She feels the need to commit Adora's lips to memory, just in case; to relish in the feeling of them as long as she's permitted.

Eventually Adora breaks the contact with a gasp - only to nose immediately against Catra's jawline and mouth along the edge.

Catra startles herself with a loud purr, strong enough to vibrate through both of their bodies. But Adora doesn't falter. If anything, it only increases heightens the frenetic energy between them as she works her way down the hollow of Catra's throat, sending a fresh line of prickling heat straight through to Catra's center.

By the time Adora's lips have reached her collarbone, Catra's breath is coming in quick. Adora kisses the bone the way she has everything else, tentative and exploratory…then sucks, hard, with zero warning. Immediately the energy snaps into something dangerous and electric; Catra cries out, louder than she has at any point so far, and her hips buck involuntarily against Adora's thigh. From the way Adora groans into the bite in response, you'd think Catra had hit a sweet spot of her own. In either case, there's a new desperation radiating off of both their bodies as she releases Catra's skin with a wet *pop*.

"Tell me what to do?" Adora's voice is breathless with need; she plants feverish kisses against Catra's neck between sentences. "Please?"

Catra lets out a sudden, rough laugh. "I have no idea. Sorry."

Adora whines with frustration; Catra can feel her teeth scrape her jawline.

"Bullshit. That's - I felt it. You were good."

Catra can't help the smile that spreads across her face as Adora continues to pepper her with kisses. "I just guessed. Did it work?"

This is finally enough to break Adora from her trance. She lifts her head from Catra's neck and shoots her a look with so much reproach that Catra can't help but laugh aloud.

"It definitely *worked,* Catra." Adora tries and fails to conceal her smile as Catra chuckles. "I wasn't exactly crying out with pain."

The thought of it makes Catra grin. But out of nowhere, another image flashes through her mind - Adora, screaming with pain as the Heart burns her alive. Her smile fades.

Adora seems to notice the shift. Her own expression softens; she begins stroking down Catra's neck with her fingers. Catra's eyes flutter shut.

"You're so important," Adora says. She seems lost in thought as her fingers card gently through Catra's fur. "I mean it. You're everything to me."

Catra squeezes her eyes tight. Her mind instinctively rejects the thought, even as she clings to it with all her might. Does Adora have the slightest idea what effect those words will have on her? Does she know how much good - how much *damage* - she can do?

"Tell me what you want," Adora whispers. She lifts her fingers to the center of Catra's lips and brushes over them, her touch light and reverent. "Please. I need you to know."

Know what? Catra questions. But her thoughts grow fevered as Adora lowers her mouth to her skin and presses soft, needy kisses down the side of her jaw. Her hands wrap tight around Adora's bare back, deepening the contact; when Catra responds, she can hear the desperation in her own voice.

"I don't know." She whimpers involuntarily when Adora's lips touch the edge of her collarbone. "I - just touch me. Please."

A brief moment of hesitation. Catra feels Adora's exhale warm her chest; her own heart continues to pound. Then Adora is shifting upward, mouth sealing wetly against hers once again - and Catra lets her mind slip.

Adora's hands are gentle, but confident. They start off exploring Catra's torso, trailing down her side and cupping her hips as they kiss. Catra's purr kicks up again, vibrations ratting through both their bodies; she hardly notices. Her tail curls upward and wraps

around Adora's calf, yet another point of contact that still doesn't feel like enough.

As Adora's fingers begin to trail past the thin fur of Catra's lower abdomen, a shudder passes through her, equal parts anticipation and terror. No one has ever touched her this intimately before - and though she has imagined it in detail countless times, always from Adora, fantasy proves inadequate preparation for the reality of it all. The idea is far-fetched enough in her mind to be unthinkable. She isn't quite sure how her body is going to respond.

When Adora's fingers push ever so slightly below the fabric of Catra's underwear, an involuntary tremor passes through her body. This is nothing like with Scorpia, senses dulled immeasurably by wine - everything is in sharp focus. She can feel each individual strand of fur standing upright beneath Adora's fingertips

"OK?" Adora's voice is soft; she is close enough for her breath to warm Catra's cheek. "Is this what you want?"

And when Catra meets Adora's gaze…oh, the sight is almost too much. She is radiant in the moons' light, her eyes large and filled with awe. Any other moment, and Catra would balk at the question; ask Adora what she wants, for once. But right now, Adora breathes through slightly parted lips, and stares at Catra - insignificant Catra - like she is the universe incarnate. And the only thought she can muster is that she can't believe, after everything they'd been through, that she was going to let this beautiful girl die alone at the center of the planet.

When she opens her mouth, the words are already waiting.

"I love you."

Adora's eyes get wide.

Mistake. The words are true, and needed to be said - but saying them here, now, was a mistake. Was hooking up with her best

friend in the middle of the woods not enough excitement for one night? She could've waited until they were in a less compromising position. Let things settle a bit longer.

But Catra barely has time for fear to grip her before Adora speaks.

"I love you too," she responds - and there is more raw affection in her voice than Catra has ever heard. "I always have."

Oh.

Catra pauses a moment to let the words fully sink in. It is unthinkable to Catra that her desire might've had a mirror all these years, all the way from the confusion of childhood to the agony of estrangement. Yet…Catra believes her. There is too much certainty in Adora's eyes for her to doubt.

So she covers Adora's hand with her own, and lets their fingers lace.

"I want this," she replies firmly.

Understanding - then, resolve - fills Adora's expression.

Without breaking their gaze, Adora begins to slip her fingers past her underwear line, making gentle contact with the tops of her curls. Catra's heart begins to pound with a new, sickening ferocity. She should probably help Adora - take them off herself, move her hand further, *something*. But the feeling of Adora's fingertips on such a sensitive part of her body paralyzes her. And much as it terrifies her to admit it…Catra doesn't want control anymore. She just wants to go soft under Adora's hands, and allow herself to be led.

Adora must sense this, somehow. There's a new confidence in her movements as she works Catra's underwear past her hip muscle, sliding it downward with her wrist. She wears the expression of a person fully present in the moment - not lost in her usual maelstrom of tactics and ruminations. It's humbling. Catra hasn't seen Adora like this in a very, very long time.

Just before she makes contact - after Catra's shorts have been pulled past her ankles, and she is fully exposed in the midnight air - Adora stops. Her expression is still absorbed, but there's enough of a pause to send a spark of anxiety to Catra's throat. Maybe she will be rejected here and now, at her most vulnerable, against all reason. Maybe it is not too late for her to hurt.

Then Adora looks up - and the love in her eyes is so glaringly, unquestionably obvious that Catra's inner monologue goes silent.

"You're perfect," Adora says simply.

She is still holding Catra's gaze when her fingers make contact with Catra's center.

The touch sends a reflexive jolt through Catra's body; she twitches up into Adora's palm, exhaling quickly. But Adora's in no rush. The first few seconds are purely exploratory, her fingertips trailing through her wetness with an almost impossible tenderness.

Catra feels frozen in place as Adora experiments with touch, pushing briefly inside her before moving to stroke between her folds. But it's not a bad sort of paralysis, this time. More like every hour of wanting, over an entire lifetime, is colliding all at once into this moment, and she has no choice but to surrender to it.

Maybe Adora feels the same. She looks younger than Catra's seen in a while; like they are both teenagers again, all the years of war and acrimony washed away in a single moment. Words seem to evade them both as she makes her way upward to Catra's clit. When Catra sighs at the contact, Adora's eyes go wide, as if discovering something new and unprecedented.

A brief, suspended moment in time - Adora's fingers lingering on Catra, Catra aware of nothing else. Then she begins moving in firm, gentle circles around the base of her clit, the way Catra used her tongue before. And Catra feels her paralysis dissolve as the

steady pattern builds heat in her center, and her world narrows to the feeling of it.

Adora is unbelievably attentive. Maybe that shouldn't come as a surprise, knowing her. Her initial clumsiness fades quickly as she experiments with different forms of touch, settling into a rhythm based on the responses of Catra's body. When Catra's occasional whimpers progress to quiet moans, it seems to carry Adora away as well. Her body dips closer and closer to Catra's, face coming to rest in the crook of her neck, and she kisses the edge of her jaw with such earnestness that Catra's heart overflows.

"You're so beautiful," she murmurs. Her fingers are soaked just from rubbing. "*So* beautiful. I love you so much."

Adora thinks she's beautiful. Adora thinks she's beautiful, and she's touching her in ways that no one ever has. Adora loves her. Adora has always loved her.

Catra might be crying again. The emotions swelling inside her are too raw and entangled to name. But she also knows that this is the most wonderful thing that's ever happened to her - ever *will* happen to her - and if she closes her eyes and presses her face close to Adora's, she can almost make the horrors that surround them disappear. So she does. And slowly, bit by bit, they do.

"Don't stop." Catra is begging now; capable of little more than clinging to Adora's back as Adora steadily works her over. "Please don't stop." *Please don't go.*

Adora just gives a choked noise of her own. She seems to realize Catra is close; there's a new energy in her movements. "OK. OK, baby. I won't."

It's embarrassing, how close those words bring her; the simple assurance of Adora's presence. Adora is breathing hard in her ear, giving Catra exactly the pressure she needs as she circles her again and again. And it's too much. It's going to break her mind into tiny pieces - and she cannot afford to be this broken right

now, with so much at stake, but the tension is building drastically inside her and she probably couldn't stop it from pouring out of her if she wanted to.

Close to madness, she mouths blindly for something to bite down on and comes upon the taut muscle of Adora's deltoid. It causes Adora to gasp, breath stuttering into a choked moan - and that is all it takes. Pleasure explodes in Catra's body as she hits her peak, and she only barely managed to stifle her cries against Adora's arm as she rocks into a blissful, choking stillness.

There are a few seconds of pure, mindless flight. Pleasure works through her in waves as she relinquishes her teeth from Adora's skin; Adora gradually slows her touch in response. As Catra has begins to relax, Adora drapes a protective arm over her waist. Then she pulls Catra close, enfolding her against the warmth of her body…and everything goes silent. Catra's thoughts and worries dissolve into the cool night air. Only Adora's strength and firm-beating heart remain.

She doesn't want to come down. It is so safe, floating above it all in these arms; a part of her fears that the thin threads holding her together will unravel completely upon her descent. But while the high of her orgasm gradually fades, the sense of security never does. Adora is here. Adora loves her. Surprisingly, that seems enough to keep Catra grounded for now.

The world around them begins to reemerge. The chirruping of wildlife; the cool dampness of the grass, offset by the heat of their bodies. Adora has started stroking Catra's forearm, up and down, in tiny movements. It's such a familiar gesture for them, engrained after years of bunking together in the Horde. How radically things have changed since then.

"I'm sorry about the bite," Catra murmurs eventually. Her voice is a bit sheepish. "Got a little overexcited."

To her relief, Adora chuckles. Her body is heavy and satisfying against Catra's own. "I liked it. I think we both had a lot to get out

of our systems.”

Catra sighs at that. The failsafe begins to ebb into her awareness once again, a most unwelcome intrusion. They couldn’t get all of this out of their system if they tried. It was simply too much.

“Fair enough,” Catra mumbles, doing her best to push it out of her mind. She fumbles sleepily for Adora’s shoulder. “Still. S’probably not the best time to be giving you any wounds, with…”

She pauses.

Adora takes notice. “What is it?”

Catra doubles back. Checks the spot again. No. She wasn’t wrong.

“Adora,” she says warily, turning in her grip to get a closer look. “You don’t…”

When she finally sets eyes on Adora’s shoulder, her suspicion is confirmed.

Smooth, bare skin. Not a trace of injury to be found. Catra knows she’d bitten down hard - she’d lost control of herself, in the moment, and was well aware of the damage her fangs could do. At the very least, there should be a mark. But there’s not.

Why isn’t there?

Adora has followed her gaze. She seems to understand, without Catra saying anything, what’s on her mind. After a brief pause, she releases her arms from Catra’s body and rolls onto her back, prodding at her muscle with her fingers.

“Weird,” she mutters, passing over the unbroken skin. Her brows furrow. “I felt it. It should have…”

A pause. Then, recognition dawns.

“She-Ra,” Adora’s eyes darken with some sort of quiet understanding. “It must be. I can’t imagine what else could’ve done it.”

“Huh.” Catra can sense there’s something more. “That’s…weird. Has that ever happened before?”

Adora doesn’t respond. Her gaze is suddenly far away.

“She’s wrong,” Adora says absently. She lifts her right hand above her face; flexes her fingers experimentally.

“Who’s wrong?” Catra asks warily. “What are you talking about?”

Adora finally turns to look at her - and Catra still isn’t sure, in that moment, what’s going on. But she can tell that Adora’s energy has shifted. She’s come to some sort of conclusion.

“They’re all wrong,” Adora whispers.

Without further clarification, she turns onto her back - and lifts an arm to the sky.

At first, there is nothing. Just the rustling of wind in nearby trees, and Catra’s faint concern that Adora is losing her mind. Then she feels her fur prick up, and the energy humming around them, the way it has countless times before. And as Catra watches, a long, shimmery sword appears in the air above Adora’s hand. The light surrounding it is uncharacteristically soft as it materializes upward from hilt to tip.

Adora lets it hover there for a moment - effortless. Then she curls her fingers inward. The sword vanishes in the same soft flicker of light it emerged from.

When Adora turns to Catra again, there is an unmistakable glow in her soft blue eyes.

“Shadow Weaver, Light Hope - they were all wrong.” Her voice rings clear in the stillness. “They said I needed to separate myself

from the people I cared about to be strong. But it's the opposite. I need you. My power…it comes from *you*."

Catra's not sure what to say in response. She's raw from the whirlwind of emotions she's experienced in the last thirty minutes; a part of her still doesn't understand what's going on. But the words manage to creep through her defenses and warm her from the inside regardless. She hadn't realized just how badly she'd needed to hear them.

"So we just needed to make out the whole time?" Catra says, trying for glib and failing. Her voice is too shaky to pull it off.

Adora doesn't respond; just lifts her hand to Catra's cheek. It's still a little wet from when she'd touched her before. Something about the realization is deeply humbling.

"I love you so much," Adora whispers.

Catra closes her eyes. The words are still foreign to her, even now - and she doesn't want them to be. She wants to forget what life was like without them. She wants to hear them, and repeat them, until they come as simply and effortlessly to her as breathing.

For now, she just leans in.

Kissing Adora, after years of just wanting to, still feels like a dream. In many ways, it's exactly how she imagined it would be - down to the familiar smell of her hair, and the slight, intoxicating clumsiness of her lips on Catra's own. But there are a few surprises, too. Like the way Adora strokes gently through Catra's fur as they kiss. Or how hesitant her touch feels at times; like Adora's questioning her own reality, as well. Questioning if this is allowed.

They eventually break for air; Catra's voice is a bit shaky in the stillness. But it no longer feels like a product of nerves. Somehow, lying naked in the woods in occupied territory, Adora has given her safety. She is in no position to deny her.

"We're going to be OK," Adora murmurs. She plants a quick kiss on each of Catra's cheeks. "I know we are. We have to be."

The words twinge; neither of them can promise that, with the entire universe at stake and that god-awful symbol burnt onto Adora's chest. But Catra can be certain now that she will be spend the remainder of her life at Adora's side, no matter how long that is. The thought brings her peace when nothing else does.

"OK," she replies simply. She leans forward and presses her lips - slightly chapped, still, from crying - against the soft skin of Adora's forehead, and holds them there. Adora sighs at the touch.

Maybe love really will be enough to carry them through this. Catra's never put much stock in the idea before - she is more familiar with its absence than anything else. But she knows that this experience has altered her more than any battle or weapon she's ever known. Right now, the idea that it might be strong enough to rouse the power of a god didn't seem very far off.

And then, there is a telltale snapping noise in the near distance.

Heightened battle reflexes are the only explanation for how they spring from post-orgasmic daze to complete activation in the blink of an eye. Catra somehow manages to grab her bra off the floor while leaping into a defensive stance - despite that being the least of her concerns, practically speaking. Adora, on the other hand, begins shimmering with bronzed light as she rises, ostensibly prepared to transform into She-Ra at the drop of a hat. Like a *cheater*.

A few more snaps, each progressively closer. Then -

"Adora? Catra? Are you guys out here?"

Glimmer. *Fuck*. She's still a ways away, but quickly gaining ground. Catra can already feel her face going beet red from the impending humiliation. Where was that *magical fucking shield cat* when she needed them?

A split second later, Catra locks eyes with Adora. She's standing buck-naked a few feet away, arm raised tentatively in front of her. And maybe Catra's insane - but she's almost positive she can transcribe the silent, frantic conversation that follows between them word-for-word.

Let me transform.

No. Fuck off.

She's right there.

Doesn't matter. You're going down with me.

There's a split second afterwards where Adora seems to wrestle with her options; she fidgets uselessly in place, her guilty conscience in clear conflict with the horrors that await if she obeys it.

Then another crack sounds - much closer, this time. And finally, Adora growls in frustration and begins scrambling for her clothes with Catra smugly following suit.

By the time they've both grabbed their outfits, Glimmer is alarmingly close. There are hints of both annnoyance and concern in her voice as she calls out.

"Guys? Seriously? I know you're out there somewhere. I literally *just* heard you talking."

Somewhere deep in Catra's heart of hearts, guilt stirs. It is kind of a dick move, triggering Glimmer's anxiety like this in the middle of a war. Catra knows that if it was her on the other end, she'd probably be pissed as hell.

…Oh well. It isn't. And for the sake of all three of them - but mostly herself - Glimmer will have to stay pissed for a little while longer.

She turns to Adora, who abruptly jerks her head downwind. Lacking any better ideas, Catra takes off in that direction, with Adora hot on her heels. She does her best to avoid excess noise, running on her toes despite the panic coursing through her body - and in spite of everything, there's a huge smile on her face, bright and chaotic and impossible to suppress. When she glances to her right, she sees Adora grinning just as hard.

Morons. Both of them.

They find a massive tree with sprawling roots to their left after a few seconds of desperate scanning. It's not a complete shield, by any means - not like a certain alien space cat she knew (seriously, where the *fuck* was Melog?) But it was large enough to shield both of their bodies at once, and when they made their way around it, she could see that there was a slight valley between two of the outermost roots. All in all, it was probably the best they were going to find short-notice, and so they settle on the floor and begin rooting frantically through their clothes.

The next thirty seconds are a mess of limbs and fabric. Catra manages to get her pants on relatively quickly, along with her sports bra - but the top has buttons, and even with natural lighting and decent night vision, it's *complicated*. She has to resist the urge to swear out loud when she realizes she's snapped the edges off-center in her haste. Panicking, she turns to lock eyes with Adora -

She's sitting there, already dressed. Staring.

"What?" Catra's whisper is breathless as she makes another fumbled attempt at the clasps. "What are you - why are you looking at me like that?"

Adora just shakes her head a little. The cracking noises are too close for comfort, but Adora doesn't seem bothered by them. The corners of her mouth crook upward into a smile.

Before Catra has time to question her further, she leans forward, gripping the front of Catra's mangled shirt, and pulls her close -

Oh. Maybe the rest didn't really matter that much, after all.

Tension drains from her body as Adora kisses her, slow and purposeful; her previous urgency is almost completely forgotten. And really, in the grand scheme of things, it's not *that* big of a deal. Nobody is hurt, neither of them are naked, and her best friend is kissing her in the moonlight. Angry squadmates aside, it's the closest to peace she's gotten in quite some time.

After a few moments - not enough - Adora pulls back. But she doesn't rush them along. The tips of their noses brush, soft and cold in the nighttime air. Adora is still smiling.

"*Guys*." Glimmer is sounding genuinely alarmed now, talking more to herself than anyone else. "If you don't randomly appear in, like, ten seconds, I'm going to have to go back for Shadow Weaver. *Please* don't make me go back for Shadow Weaver."

Catra winces; they've been toying with her long enough. But for once, Adora seems completely at ease. She reaches to cup Catra's face and holds her gaze with a relaxed smile.

"I love you," she says. A quick, chaste kiss - and then she withdraws.

"Take your time. I'll make something up."

With that, she disappears from view.

They are completely screwed. Adora can't act for shit; even if she does manage to pull a decent excuse out of her ass, there's no way Sparkles isn't going to call bullshit on them both being out here *together*. She's going to murder them both with her bare hands the second they're in arms reach

But it feels like such a silly thing to be worried about - getting caught sneaking around by their furious best friend. And Catra

likes that. Regardless of the outcome, things are about to get more deadly serious than they've ever been before. She will take moments like this as they come.

There is no lingering desire to run in Catra's body as she settles against the base of the tree, toying languidly with her clasps. Adora has drained the urge right out of her. She will carry the pain of what's happened for a while yet - but she will carry it to the Heart. She will fight for Adora, and the rest of them, until the bitter end.

There are worse ways to die than standing at the side of a girl who loves you.

End Notes

SW: hey I need you to go get Catra and Adora they're outside

Glimmer: I mean ok but why don't you just go get them

SW: …

SW: gonna need you to trust me on this one

(Thanks for reading as always 💕 💕 💕 now to respond to all your lovely comments from the LAST fic)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!